

Hindu Cattle Breeders of Northwest India and Problems of Their Current Transition, Exemplified by the Rabari¹

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General information about the Hindu cattle breeders of Northwest India settlement area

In the northwest of the Indian subcontinent, according to local traditions, cattle herding is said to have been the dominant way of life up to 1,000 years ago, from Rajasthan in the north to Gujarat in the south, and from Sindh in the west to Mewar in the east, and up to the present day, there are groups that live exclusively or predominantly from livestock breeding. Preferably, in areas unsuitable for cultivation, there are groups that live solely from camel, buffalo, cattle, sheep, or goat breeding. However, they sometimes also settle far into arable land, with the respective subgroups splitting up so much that they can graze their herds between the fields claimed by the villages, or they integrate as livestock-breeding specialist groups consisting of only a few families into the villages of the sedentary population in special residential quarters.

Classification within the Hindu Caste System

Insofar as these cattle breeders are counted among the Islamic Baluchs and Afghans, they are generally - i.e. not in every individual case - tribal organizations. One can even go so far as to say that the Islamic influence among livestock groups in Northwest India is indicated by a political organization that corresponds to the tribal organization of shepherds who migrated down from the Iranian plateau, although it has often been adapted to local circumstances. The Hindu cattle breeders, on the other hand, have no tribal organizations and no tribal leader, but at best one or a few socially and, if necessary, also politically leading families, whose status depends decisively on the personality of the currently living head of the family. In rare cases, livestock families have preserved and retained land, and since land ownership in Northwest India gives prestige, the more significant position of these families then becomes a permanent institution. Otherwise, she takes care of Hindu Cattle breeders prevailing equality of all male group members so that the most impressive personality finds the greatest support in the election of a group leader.

The absence of political tribal organizations is due to the Hindu caste system, which attributes and reserves the task of warlike defense and conquest of land to a certain caste. In many respects, Northwest India is even the area in which the division of the various public functions into certain castes could be better observed than in all other parts of India, until the British also took over here. The territory of the warlike Rajputs was never subjugated for the long term by the powerful Islamic dynasties in the western Sind and in the eastern Panj, although the ruling houses of the Rajputs could be obliged to pay tributes after military defeats, which they repeatedly discontinued if they felt

¹ With the support of the DFG and the Senate of Berlin, my husband and I were able to carry out the following field studies: 1961/62 for the Jat in West Pakistan, 1963/64 for the Jat in Kutch/Gujrat, 1968/69 for the Bharvad, Charan and Rabari in Gujrat and Rajasthan/India.

strong enough to do so. In Rajasthan, Gujrat, Saurashtra and Kutch, all population groups - including Hindu cattle breeders - had to pay taxes to the local rulers, who mostly came from the Rajputen caste². Like all other castes, they expected military protection in return and only reached for weapons when it was necessary to ward off a direct threat to their groups or their herds. They corresponded and correspond to the coercion of self-defense in their migrations, but they are not attacking, warly spirit, which would have been reflected in a code of honor, which failed them to avoid threats and inconveniences by wandering away, especially - formerly - evasion into unsited areas. This evasion to areas inaccessible or unsuitable for cultivation also usually brought the advantage that one could thus escape the never-popular levies on local rulers. In their traditions, the attempt to use them for taxes is often mentioned as the reason that caused them to make wandering movements.

In the Hindu caste system, cattle herders held a relatively respected position³ at least the cattle herders, because cow milk played a significant role both ritually and in the diet of Brahmanical society. However, the production and sale of dairy products were detrimental to the social standing of cattle herders.⁴ The sale of unprocessed milk, on the other hand, was and is considered unworthy of a true cattle herder and is still taboo among traditionally living groups for irrational reasons.⁵

Currently, cattle herders as a whole are regarded as a caste by farmers and city dwellers alike, and any group that specializes in breeding one or more animals is also referred to as a caste. This corresponds to the current use of the term caste in India, since the Vedic concept of the four-caste division of society has evolved into an increasingly refined caste differentiation based on occupation. The sale of unprocessed milk, on the other hand, was considered unworthy of a true cattle herder and is still taboo among traditionally living groups today for irrational reasons.

The general view in the area we visited is that the Ahir are—or were—the cattle herders, the Charan the herders of oxen or buffalo, the Rabari the camel herders, and the Bharvad the herders of sheep and goats. This classification is not accurate today, and whether it ever was in the past is doubtful, since ethnic, caste, and occupational designations, as far as can be historically ascertained for these groups, have not had a sharp demarcation from one another.⁶ Nevertheless, this fundamental distinction reveals the understanding that the breeding of different animals entails a corresponding way of life, and this remains true to this day.

² MacMurdo, Kattiwar, S. 276: Selections No XXXIX, S. 26, S. 40.

³ Baines, S. 56: "The prominent place assigned to cattle in the Sūktas and the universal veneration of the Brāhmanic community for the cow bear testimony to the antiquity as to the honourable character of the calling, and in upper India the cattle breeder ranks almost as high as the cultivator."

⁴ Baines, S. 56: "Furthermore, the supply of milk for the home is by all Vedic traditions, commendable, but the sale of dairy produce as a trade entails relegation to a lower position."

⁵ Westphal-Hellbusch / Westphal, 1964, S. 65 - 68; Westphal-Hellbusch / Westphal 1968, S. 126, 209, 266.

⁶ Westphal-Hellbusch, Changes ...

Migration patterns

The Hindu cattle herders are considered immigrants, as evidenced by their habitus. They are all tall, slender, sinewy types with comparatively light brown skin, but dark hair and brown eyes. Where and when the first migration to India may have occurred cannot be discussed here, but it can be proven that they migrated to their present-day settlements, some only in the last centuries. The general direction of their migration was from north to south, although individual groups may have temporarily followed each of the other four cardinal directions on their long journey. This will be explained in more detail in the section on the Rabari. What is important in this context is the fact that they inserted themselves among the settled population and had to adapt to the prevailing living conditions and circumstances. It is a slow process of infiltration and not of conquering land.

The 13th century is a frequently cited period of intense migrations, triggered by armed conflicts between the Hindu Rajputs and the Muslim Ala uddin Khilji (1295–1315 AD). Clear connections between these accounts and actual historical events are often difficult to establish, as Ala uddin Khilji personifies the Islamic adversary in this region, as in the Panj ab Mahmud of Ghazni (997–1030 AD). However, Islamic and Hindu chronicles indicate that in the 11th–13th centuries, the Rajputs were driven from their northern settlements in Punjab to the south and east by Muslim warlords.⁷ Since the Rajputs had always been patrons of the cattle herders, and the herders themselves were hardly unaffected by the war, quite a few likely joined their patrons during this period of southward migration.⁸

It is unlikely that the cattle herding groups discussed here only immigrated to the Indian subcontinent at this time. According to their own traditions, they have been part of the population of India since mythological times. For example, the Charan claim to be Deviputra (sons of the goddess), the Rabari a creation of Parvati, the consort of Shiva, and the Bharvad assert that they belonged to the retinue of Krishna, but this says nothing about their origin and history. The Islamized cattle herders also sought to connect with the mythical lineage of the Arabs.⁹ In both cases, this involves a fictitious equality of ancestry and religious belief with the ruling class. This equality, even if it is questioned, is nevertheless a prerequisite for the cattle herders to find a place in Hindu or Islamic society.

The cattle herders' relationships with other castes

⁷ Baines . S. 29.

⁸ Many Rajputs are said to have sought refuge with the cattle breeders during this time, which in several cases led to marriages. As a result, according to the Hindu caste laws, not only the married warriors themselves lost their rank, but also their descendants. However, they kept the group name of their fathers, which explains the pre-emption of so many groups with Ra j puten names among the cattle breeders.

⁹ Westphal-Hellbusch / Westphal, 1968, S. 80/81.

For all the groups forced to migrate, livestock farming secured their livelihood. Even the Rajputs, interested in land acquisition, claim to have been cattle herders (Maldhari) in the past. Accordingly, the local tradition of Kutch, Saurashtra, and Rajasthan states that "in earlier times" there were only cattle herders in the land, with "in earlier times" being very vaguely placed back a few hundred to a thousand years. This is demonstrably false. There had been a farming population there at least since the time of Alexander,¹⁰ upon whose yields the ruling class and the townspeople depended, insofar as the townspeople were not themselves farmers. Those immigrants who had an inclination to do so, or saw no other way of life, than to continue to dedicate themselves to pure cattle farming, could only do so thanks to these farming groups, with whom they conducted and still conduct trade. Then, as now, the cattle herders were dependent on the craftsmen of the villages and towns.

Many cattle herders who immigrated as refugees, however, settled down, as they possessed knowledge of cultivation, such as the Ahir in Kutch and Saurashtra, the Rabari in Kutch, and so on. Even today, pure cattle herders can practice rain-fed agriculture when famine forces them to. Unlike Islamic or Islamized herders, they do not look down on farmers with arrogance, although many confess that they prefer their unattached way of life to that of a settled lifestyle. Furthermore, when assessing the mutual perceptions of farmers and cattle herders, it must be taken into account that, at least in the last centuries before the beginning of British rule, in the areas under Rajput control, the internal feuds of these warriors—which resulted in the plundering of villages¹¹ often depopulated entire regions of farmers. These people then sought refuge in the territory of a ruler who could effectively protect them, or withdrew with their livestock for longer or shorter periods to inaccessible areas. They tended to return to their old settlements, even if sometimes only after decades. In this way, not only did the farmers gain populations from the livestock herders, but the latter also gained populations from the settled population.

The knowledge of a period of purely nomadic livestock herding in their own distant or recent past often leads members of today's farming or warrior class to claim that important cultural achievements in this area arose from the care of livestock. Thus, in northwestern India, with the exception of the lands along the Indus and its tributary canals, water supply is the biggest problem. Only wells and artificially created water reservoirs¹² secure a livelihood for farmers and cattle herders in many areas, and often enough, even today, threatening famines arise when several unfavorable dry years cause

¹⁰ Vgl. R. C. Majumdar, p. 65 ff. According to new excavation finds, cultivation crops in Saurashtra go back to 2000 BC. Cf. M. R. Majmudar, p. 10 ff.

¹¹ The depictions of the history of the Indian states and small states as given by Mehta and Mehta bear witness to this. 523, 552, 634, 657, 687. Tod's composition of the history of the Rajputana dynasties can also be used as an example. See also Powlett, p. 86.

¹² So-called Tanks or Jheels, in which mostly geographically natural collection points of the monsoon water are converted into permanent lakes or ponds, by preventing a barrier wall, deeper excavation and fixing the walls from draining the water.

these water sources to dry up.¹³ Cattle herders and farmers now claim that the first wells and tanks in the country were built by cattle herders, following the examples seen at cities and sanctuaries.

In some cases, this is demonstrably true, such as in the north of Kutch. In Lodrani, where just a few decades ago people are said to have lived exclusively from cattle herding, it was reported that in 1700 S.(equivalent to 1644 AD) Jamrabai, a wealthy cattle herder, built a tank there for watering the animals, which is still used today for this purpose, but also for the cultivation that has since begun. It also seems to have been common for rulers, cities, or sanctuaries interested in cattle herders or their products to establish cattle watering places for them.¹⁴

The cattle herders who migrated to and wandered through Rajasthan, Kutch, and Saurashtra did not find the land empty, but large parts of the uncultivable and also the cultivable land had only a nominal owner.¹⁵ The cattle herding groups inserted themselves into these gaps in the settlement and had to adapt their way of life to very different geographical and historical conditions. The extent to which subgroups of a "caste" can diverge as a result will be shown later by the example of the Rabari. Here, some cultural characteristics that identify the cattle herders as Hindu cattle herders will be highlighted.

The Importance of Kinship and Territory for Community Life

Such characteristics cannot be derived from their activities, or rather, they share these traits with Islamic livestock herders. These include, for example, the production and sale of dairy products to settled residents and buyers; the sale of male calves at the festive markets (melas) held in the residential and migratory area; regulated contact with settled residents; management of the farm by women; other division of labor between the sexes, etc. The cultural traits that unite all Hindu livestock herders and simultaneously distinguish them from Islamic herders are attributable to influences from their cultural environment.

As already mentioned, the livestock herders, as members of a Hindu caste, do not have a political tribal organization. Social organizations extending beyond the local group are formed based on shared ties through descent or as a result of settling a common territory. Common ancestry can be proven through blood kinship either by genealogists or established as caste kinship through an ever-increasing recourse to mythical ancestral lines. Recognized kinship creates a sense of belonging, but no formative force for social organizations, with the exception of the limitation, to a certain extent, of the circle of possible marriage partners. Nevertheless, even in this respect, the shared

¹³ Even the earliest reports from travelers and the British depict devastating famines. Cf. Forbes, p. 511; Commissariat, p. 188, 312 - 22, 394, 495; Mehta and Mehta, p. 500, Dto. Minor States, S. 88, 229; Walter, Mallani, S. 286; Baylay, Sirohi, S. 122; Powlett, Bikanir, p. 94 and others. These not only destroyed people and animals through hunger, thirst and plagues, but also triggered local migration movements, which made a significant contributor to the fragmentation and isolation of subgroups.

¹⁴ Vgl. Latouche, S. 25: "The tanks were constructed and used exclusively for the purpose of providing water for the cattle. No revenue or rent was paid." Diese Regelung galt bis 1822.

¹⁵ For the devastation of the country by feuden to be made responsible for this, cf. p. 53, as well as note. 11).

territory and the resulting acquaintance are more important than the recognized kinship. Rabari in Rajasthan and Rabari in Kutch, for example, recognize each other as caste-related and theoretically acknowledge possible marriages between the two groups – in practice, they know of no such cases and currently consider their occurrence unlikely. When such widely separated groups of Rabari meet during migrations, they feel hardly a closer sense of belonging than with migrating groups of other livestock-herding castes.

As "brothers of the blanket,"¹⁶ they maintain peace in foreign territory whenever possible. Compared to no other livestock-herding group do the Rabari have to observe dietary laws; they can eat uncooked and cooked food together, accept water from one another,¹⁷ and smoke together. It has been credibly assured that food is even shared with migrating groups of Islamic livestock herders, and that from the perspective of the Hindu caste system, all livestock herders are equally respected members of one caste—in the broader sense. Accordingly, the "brothers of the blanket" feel a sense of belonging together, which awakens a certain willingness to help, which also includes vague bonds with one another. But all these feelings do not develop any formative power for potentially resulting social relationships. The situation is different with territorially given cohesion.

The territory that the Rabari inhabit is, with a few exceptions, not their own. Although some of the men can regularly be on the move with herds for up to 10 months a year – even for several years in a row during times of famine – all groups have permanent settlements where the family members who are unable to migrate are left behind. At these settlements, the Rabari could not and still cannot evade paying dues to the landowner or the government of the land; however, this also legalized their relationships with these entities. Previously, they used these dues to purchase grazing rights and the protection of the local ruler. This explains why the territorial associations of the cattle herders were often oriented towards the domains of their protectors. If the territorial associations had existed for a longer period and thus experienced a certain consolidation, the territorial associations of today's Rabari can reflect such older spheres of influence, even though these themselves no longer exist. Several Rabari in Rajasthan told us that they belonged to a community of 24 villages, i.e., the residential areas of the Rabari at 24 villages considered themselves a single, cohesive community. Usually, fewer than 24 villages were named, which suggests that some villages have been abandoned since the beginning of the association. We found no one who could explain this fact or the number 24. Literature shows that 24 villages, along with 64 and 84, was a traditionally common unit of land given, granted, or assigned for use.¹⁸

¹⁶ Dhablabhai. As an indispensable garment of all wandering shepherds, the blanket made of sheep wool, which men usually wear over one shoulder. It serves them on all occasions: folded in a special way as a rain cover; depending on the circumstances as a sleeping or seat blanket. A good blanket should last at least 10 years, and it is claimed that a cattle breeder values his blanket more than his wife and family.

¹⁷ Which, according to the very strict Hindu ideas in this relationship, means that givers and acceptors have exactly the same social rank, so that neither one nor the other sinks into the degree of "purity" by accepting water or food.

¹⁸ Vgl. Mehta and Mehta, p. 488; same minor states, p. 25; Forbes, p. 288; 299, 281; Selections No. XXXIX, P. 319; Elliot, Part III, p. 46; Death, II, p. 223.

That actual power relations were decisive for territorial associations of the cattle herders was demonstrated by... B. in the fact that in the southwest of Saurashtra the Rabari organized themselves according to the five temples of the Momai-Mata, whose priests exercised judicial functions in specifically demarcated areas. In other cases, the cattle herders in certain regions with particular living conditions have banded together and derived their group names from them, such as the Sorathia among the Charan and Rabari – derived from Sorath, meaning Saurashtra – or the Dheberya after the Dheber region east of Kutch, among others. All of this will be elaborated upon later. Generally speaking, it should first be noted that the common territory, recognized in some aspect and personified by the officially recognized spokesperson, is the most important demarcation against other groups.

Regulation of internal and external affairs

A group that considers itself autonomous regulates its internal affairs independently of the jurisdiction to which it was subject as part of the population in a former territory and to which it is subject today in an administrative unit. The representatives of the local subgroups in the general council, which accompanies internal court sessions, are intended to represent the community as fully as possible. As with all castes in India that had no ruling functions to fulfill—whose continuity was ensured by hereditary succession—the cattle herders organized their community affairs through a so-called Panchayat, i.e., through representatives of their territorial unit and the local groups that constitute it. Panchayat can best be translated as "council of five," however, it turned out that the number was not and is not binding, but rather that among cattle herders today, Panchayat refers to all bodies appointed by the community to settle disputes and to preside over the community meetings associated with any legal proceedings on a local and regional basis. Besides these councils, which were only responsible for internal affairs, each local group and the larger territorial unit had a spokesperson who represented it externally and had to be officially recognized by the respective government. This made the spokesperson, to varying degrees locally, an official of the ruler or the government and accordingly received a title—Patel, Mukhi, Sinai, or Desai, depending on local circumstances. As an outward symbol of his dignity, he usually received a turban and a recognition fee or exemption from taxes, a percentage share of the taxes paid to the government by his other community members, or even conditional use of land. In principle, these public officials were supposed to be elected and recallable representatives of their community, but in practice, external influences could exert themselves through them. For example, a spokesman compliant with the ruler was occasionally retained by him against the will of his community, or the ruler allocated land to him, which, due to the generally customary inheritance of land claims, also resulted in the office of spokesman becoming hereditary and thus creating a permanence that disrupted the traditional electability of the officeholder, disregarding personal suitability.

Religious beliefs

For reasons not detailed here,¹⁹ the Hindu cattle herders are ardent followers of the local mother goddesses, the so-called Matas. They also observe all the general Hindu festivals such as Diwali, Holi, and the Nine Nights, and they do not neglect to worship the major gods of Hinduism, such as Shiva, Vishnu, and Krishna. Cattle herders have a more intense relationship with Krishna, the Indian god of herders, than with the other major deities. The worship of the Matas is a characteristic that unites all Hindu cattle herders and distinguishes them from the Islamic tribes. A particularly important reason for this is that the Matas, some of whom are local goddesses dating back to pre-Islamic times, possessed temple areas that were spared by Hindu rulers as much as possible because they themselves often provided them with protection and refuge. The right of asylum granted to them and the donations of land often made the Matas' places of worship powerful supra-local institutions, which—given the priesthood's inclination—gained political or social influence, which in some cases they can still exercise to a modest extent to this day.²⁰

With few exceptions, all groups of cattle herders were associated with such local goddesses and were under their protection. Some of these Matas had become, as it were, symbols of the unity of such groups of people, so that they were taken along when the group migrated and places of worship were also erected for them in the new settlements. In such cases, a protective and offensive alliance could develop between the temple priest and the religious community. An example of this is Momai-Mata, whom the Rabari of Kutch took with them to Saurashtra, first to the Barda Hills and then to the Gir Forest. Another example is Vankol-Mata, who was also brought from Sindh by the Rabari and reintroduced to Saurashtra. It seems that no qualms were about housing one's own Mata in the temple of the most frequently existing native Mata, as it is not uncommon for several Matas to be worshipped in one sanctuary.²¹ We saw this, for example, in a temple in Rapar/Kutch. Here, from left to right on the altar, first stood Momai-Mata sculpted in clay, riding a camel, then side by side, highlighted by painting on an imaginative stone: Ambaji, Ravechi, Momai, Kodiar, and Ashapura. In the temple of Momai Mora near Fatehgarh in northeast Kutch, the goddesses Lakshmi and Shita were also located in a side room. In the temple of Avad-Mata, in the Temra Hills near Jaisalmir, Avad-Mata and her six sisters were worshipped, some of whom have their own temples elsewhere; and these examples are not isolated cases.

Besides the Matas, the herders also worship horse heroes,²² who are mostly deified Rajput warriors. They are the ones to whom people turn primarily in the everyday troubles of a herding and nomadic

¹⁹ Vgl. Westphal-Hellbusch, *Goddesses*, in print.

²⁰ Examples would be the temple of the Karneji-Mata in Deshnok, in the former domain of the Rathors in Bikanir, or the temple of the Ashapura in Matanomadh/Kutch, the family goddess of the Jhareja who ruled there until 1948.

²¹ Such juxtapositions do not offer the Hindu doctrine of faith in that all female deities can be understood as aspects of the primordial mother (Shakti). If several Matas are represented in a temple, the primal mother is revered there in several aspects, whereby it apparently does not cause the believers any mental difficulties to assume that the aspect they prefer, namely her Mata, is particularly accessible to their requests.

²² Westphal-Hellbusch, 1971, S. 1-28.

life, for example, when animals have strayed, when parts of the herd have been stolen by cattle thieves, in times of epidemics, and when there is trouble in dealings with the settled population.²³

The position of women

As a final point that characterizes Hindu cattle herders, the privileged position of their wives should be mentioned. While it is certainly noteworthy that the management of the farm is entirely in their hands, the fully responsible management of the farm by the woman during the absence of the men, who are away on their travels, and the resulting influential position in family life, is also found among Islamic cattle herders. This separation of spheres of activity and responsibility is enforced by their way of life. For the general perception of men, however, there are no such compelling reasons. Men are considered fundamentally less intelligent and short-sighted; therefore, they require constant supervision and guidance from the women. Since peasant cunning and merchants' slyness can easily deceive the men, all sales and purchases are handled by the women. The merchants fear the cattle herders' wives, who haggle with a tenacity and persistence that ultimately wears down their resistance. One consequence of this is that they mock the men of the cattle herders and circulate anecdotes about them, which are then adopted by members of other castes. It is generally acknowledged, however, that the women keep the cattle herders debt-free, in striking contrast to the often heavily indebted farmers. Nevertheless, it seems ridiculous to the other castes that the men have to ask the women for pocket money, which is only given to them sparingly; some men still cannot even afford a cup of tea in town or at the market. During our village visits, the women often decided, either with gestures or words, whether the men were allowed to give information or not, and often enough they soon abandoned all initial courtesy and took the floor from the man to speak for themselves. Not infrequently, they even remarked that the men were too stupid to answer. Women are never made officials of the territorial units, so they are not officially represented in the Panchayat and at the community assemblies. Here, they must exert their influence indirectly through men.

The influential position of women is therefore not solely due to economic reasons. The cattle herders themselves argue that women, by virtue of their gender, are closer to the Matas than they are and perhaps truly share in their power and wisdom, for women can be possessed by a Mata who then speaks through them.²⁴ The example of the Rajput women, the women of the ruling class, may also have exerted a certain influence, of whom it is said that they marry the land and not the man,²⁵ and

²³ Whether this cultural trait, which is also characteristic of the Hindu cattle breeders, stands out from those of the Islamic breeders, would have to be checked on the spot. In our investigations of the Baluch and Jat in the lower Sind and in Kutch, we did not investigate this question, as neither observations nor information gave a reference to equestrian heroes. It can only be said with certainty that in this area the possible worship of equestrian heroes does not play a major role among Islamic cattle breeders; nevertheless, it remains open whether closer reviews would not result in traces, remains or partial takeover of this complex.

²⁴ Vgl. Westphal-Hellbusch, Goddesses.

²⁵ MacMurdo, 1820, Cutch, S. 226 - 227, und Jacob, S. 34: "The wives of the Rajpoots have generally more to do with the management of their estates than their lords; these are sunk in sloth

are constantly involved in intrigues to bring their own sons to power. It is not possible to trace the roots of this complex further here, but it must be taken into account in the following discussion.

Rabari Generally

This paper asks: What problems and ways of adaptation can be observed among the Rabari? The problems are similar to those of other cattle herders, but also vary locally. In view of the main research question, all ethnographic data or even descriptions, including all depictions of the social, political, and religious life of the Rabari, have been omitted. (A publication on this topic is in preparation.) The preceding general chapter on Hindu cattle herders is intended to aid in understanding the details that follow and to provide a meaningful context for them.

The Rabari have received little attention in the literature. Enthoven²⁶ provides the most detailed account, comprising seven pages, which, it must be noted, is essentially based on material about the Rabari in Kutch. In other publications, they are mentioned only briefly and are rarely listed separately from other cattle herders in census surveys. Thus, their numbers could only ever be estimated.

In 1901, their number in Gujarat²⁷ was 2,215,664, and in Rajputana²⁸ 99,099. In 1931, their number in Rajputana was 135,820, and their total number can therefore be estimated at 415,000 for the year 1931. Since 1931, the Indian government has consciously pursued a policy against the caste system and has replaced caste names with religious and occupational designations in its census surveys, so that no more recent statistical data on the Rabari is available. In any case, the Rabari, like all others, have suffered an incalculable loss through migration and disappearance into the anonymity of the large cities. With all due reservations, one could therefore perhaps describe 500,000 people as Rabari today.

Neither descriptive nor statistical information about the main areas of their distribution can be found in the literature. The overview we sought led to the following result: There are two main areas of distribution. The first lies in the area that the locals refer to as the "real island of Kutch"; the Dheber region, which extends quite far into the center of the island from the east, is not part of this. The Rabari are most numerous in the districts of Lakhpat and Nakatrana, as well as on the central southern coast. In the east of the island, they are concentrated in the Dheber and Waghar regions. In Saurashtra, there are also two main areas of distribution: firstly, in the Barda Hills in the southwest, and secondly, in the Gir Forest in the southeast. In between and further north, they settle sporadically. All of northern Gujarat is a dense Rabari settlement area; here they live in an inextricable mixture with other pastoralist and agricultural castes. A special group is formed by the Rabari in the metropolis of Ahmedabad, who make their living from selling milk.

and debauchery, whilst the ladies, whose intellect the use of opium has not clouded, hold, either directly, or indirectly the reins of government."

²⁶ Enthoven, Vol. III, S. 252-258.

²⁷ Gaz. of the Bombay Pres., Vol. IX.

²⁸ Census of India, Vol. XXVII, Rajputana Agency.

Palanpur and its surroundings, i.e., the Banaskhanta district, must be seen in the geographical context of southern Rajasthan. The area around Mount Abu is considered by the Rabari to be one of their most important settlement areas, especially the Sirohi district. The main area of distribution in Rajasthan is the southern part of the Marwar district, with its capital Jodhpur. The Jaisalmer district, which most Rabari consider their historical homeland, is now almost entirely deserted by them. In the belt surrounding the aforementioned area, from northern Rajasthan to eastern Gujarat, Rabari are found in increasingly scattered and smaller groups and in growing dependence on settled communities. Generally speaking, the present northern and eastern border region of their distribution is the area from which they have withdrawn through southward and southwestward migrations. In parallel with this migration movement, the groups that remained behind lost social significance.

The western group of Rabari in Kutch

This group is distinguished from all other groups by its settlement area, called Kutchi, and the Kutchi themselves still refer to themselves as such today. They are of very mixed origins. In several small waves, they migrated from Sindh to Kutchi 700-600 years ago, but the migration from Gujarat westward through northern Saurashtra also produced splinter groups that settled in this area. A characteristic feature of the Kutchi is that they were allocated land for settlement. In some cases, members of the ruling Jhareja Rajputs actually gifted them a portion of the village land, specifically the third allocated to the Jhareja from each settlement; in other cases, they allowed them to lease land. As a result, the Kutchi do not have their own settlements but only residential areas attached to the villages. Settlements are said to exist in 100 villages, with the number of families living in each varying between 10 and 40. The Kutchi are considered by the other Rabari to be the model for Rabari living in a traditional way, as indeed the west of the island remained in relatively undisturbed, traditional conditions until a few years ago. In fact, many of them are still camel herders today, although some have already taken over the farmers' animals—either alongside or exclusively—i.e., cows, oxen, buffalo, and in some cases, sheep and goats. The camel herders in Kutch migrate as close as possible to their villages. In times of famine, however, the men also move with the herds to Saurashtra and Gujarat, something they are not forced to do too often, since camels thrive in semi-deserts—provided there is a minimum of water. In recent years, the development of the western part of the country has been undertaken for military reasons, which means a progressive reduction in grazing opportunities for camel herders. They are forced to consider changing their way of life. Their limited geographical and cultural horizon leaves them with only one option: transitioning to agriculture. The "landowning" Rabari, in particular, face unforeseen difficulties.

The land they were given or leased had previously only been used for cultivation in isolated cases, or even sublet to farmers who cultivated it for the usual fees. After 1953, a land reform was initiated in India, stipulating that only those who had cultivated their land themselves could retain it. Depending on the geographical conditions, a maximum limit per person was set, which was usually 3 acres – slightly more than one hectare. Those Rabari who had leased their fields to farmers were thus considered to belong to the landowning, exploiting class. Only a few quickly understood that they

had to seek their salvation in cultivating their land in order to save their right to live and their property, or to have the leased land granted to them as their own property. We met some such families in Nakatrana and the surrounding area, on the south coast, and also in the Magh region. The majority of the Rabari lost their homes and land without really understanding what was happening. In belated realization, they now complain that they are forced to wander about, as rootless nomads, which they claim they were not. They subsequently try to explain their situation, to reclaim the old land in order to cultivate it, but the officials appointed by the government in Ahmedabad are still too busy with the further implementation of the land reform to show much interest in this special case.

Dheberya and Wagharya/Kutch

In the two eastern regions of Dheber and Waghar, there are hardly any landowning Rabari, but several large villages inhabited exclusively by them. These are the permanent settlements of the nomadic Rabari, who leave behind all family members unable to travel during their migrations, which usually last ten months. Their total number was estimated by an official at 3,000 families, a figure that corresponds well with information provided by the Rabari themselves. The westward- and southward-oriented Dheberya only leave Kutch in years of extreme famine, while the eastward-oriented Dheberya regularly migrate to Saurashtra and Gujrat, returning during the monsoon season. These two months of all family members being together are a time of very intense community life. Funeral ceremonies are held, inheritances are settled, weddings are celebrated, pending disputes are mediated, and the festive markets that fall during this time are attended.

The camel is traditionally highly valued by the Dheberya and Wagharya, but they only keep a few animals for prestige reasons; their primary livestock are sheep and secondarily goats. As sheep and goat herders, they migrated from Gujrat to Kutch. They had a particularly prized wool-bearing sheep breed, the Patwari sheep, which thrived so well in Kutch that its numbers had risen to about 800,000 twenty years ago. These enormous flocks were grazed by the Rabari, except during times of famine, primarily on the Banni peninsula north of Kutch, which has always held great appeal for them. Banni is still exclusively inhabited by livestock herders, who raise large animals there, such as buffalo, cattle, and oxen. The Rabari sheep could be fed in good years, when the grass was man-high; in bad years, they grazed the grass before it could properly grow, leaving nothing for the animals of the local livestock farmers. They succeeded in having the Rabari banned from migrating to Banni about 20 years ago.

Since then, this group has been forced to adapt, but for the time being, they are not considering any cultivation, instead trying to adapt with their sheep farming. They have increasingly abandoned their own sheep breed in favor of the Marwari sheep. This breed is a better migratory animal, and after the loss of Banni, many Rabari are now forced to migrate farther. While wool and milk are of lower quality, the crucial point is that the Marwari sheep is a better meat animal. The ever-increasing demand of the cities provides a readily available market for meat, and one gets a good price for the animal. The migrations proceed in the traditional manner, but increasingly in close connection with certain merchant families who guarantee the sale of wool, ghi (butterfat), and meat. Only the

merchants always know where their groups can be found. It is important and promising that some Rabari have taken up trading and enjoy the special trust of their caste brothers. Recently, these Rabari have developed the tendency to have more wives and children with them; the men could never process the milk entirely without women. However, family members are not allowed to migrate along, but are notified when good pasture has been found, and they then follow by omnibus or train. The permanent houses in Kutch are meanwhile guarded by friendly families. If the men have to continue their journey, they send their wives and children home and can have them join them again at a later opportunity. This makes it easier for them to decide to stay away from their homeland for years if necessary, even though they clearly recognize the dangers this poses to their community life.

Sorathia-Rabari in the Barda Hills / Saurashtra

Previously, the Barda Hills were only frequented by the Rabari, while the permanent settlers there were rebels against the petty lords, of whom there were particularly many in Saurashtra. At the beginning of the last century, the Englishman Lilie²⁹ was appointed regent for the young Jethwa queen in Porbandar. He established the state borders with Jamnagar and Junagadh and regulated the land distribution within the state; the tax system was also organized. The Barda Hills and the adjoining Alech range were reserved entirely for the Maldhari, the cattle herders, i.e., in this case, the Rabari. The area that Lilie did not declare a Crown forest reserve, he divided among the Rabari as residential territory. They lived in so-called nesses, in temporary, relocatable settlements.³⁰

For each Ness, a specific grazing area was designated, which also had sufficient water resources; cattle ranchers were generally not allowed to enter the forest reserves, or only with special permission. No fees were payable for the grazing areas, but a poll tax per animal was stipulated. This regulation and the expulsion of the rebels prompted the Rabari to settle permanently in the Barda Hills, and since later governments also adhered to the regulation established by Lilie, the Rabari lived here in secure, orderly conditions.

After 1947, the government classified this group of Rabari as belonging to the backward castes, which had the great advantage that they automatically received all the aid measures and support provided for these castes. Specifically, this meant that in 1953/54 every nuclear family was allocated 3 acres of land and new houses. A school was also established for them near Ness Kileshwar. Without further financial support, and especially without guidance from the government, the Rabari viewed the land only as pasture and mostly abandoned it during the frequent famines to seek better grazing. The school, which the Rabari did not consider necessary, also proved to be a failure. In contrast, a school founded in 1951 near Jharera, largely through the initiative of some Rabari, where both teachers are Rabari, managed to survive until 1969 despite all the difficulties.

These teachers have developed further plans to help their fellow Rabari adapt to the new era. They want to expand the small farm, where the students are already being taught cultivation, into a

²⁹ Administrative Report, Porbandar State, Vol. I.

³⁰ In the Porbandar part of the Barda Hills, there are today 37 Nesses, in the Jamnagar assigned part 26 and in the Alech chain 16 Nesses. In 1969, the number of Rabari was estimated by the Forestry Administration at 1000 families.

profitable large-scale operation in which the children's fathers could also work. A cooperative is also planned, which is to conclude a contract with the government for the economic use of designated forest areas. All these plans are to be implemented with the help of the Rabari's experience. It would be more promising to support these plans than the individual actions of some family men to reclaim the land awarded to them in 1953 but subsequently relinquished, but so far the school principals have lacked official interest and support.

A large-scale attempt by this Sorathia group to gain a better starting position for social advancement overall remained without tangible success, but is not yet considered a complete failure. In 1958, the group adopted a written constitution, which was signed by all religious and secular leaders. Until 1958, the highest jurisdiction lay in the hands of the leading priests of the five temples of the Momai-Mata, who administered justice according to ancient tradition with a fixed ceremony. This right is taken away from them in the secular constitution, which contains 17 articles and also seeks to fundamentally change some old traditions. The main goals are: the abolition of child marriages and the bride price, and the legal improvement of women's status. This is intended to demonstrate that the Rabari have overcome their backwardness and should now be given every opportunity for advancement in the civil service. The driving forces behind the large council meeting of 1958 and its constituent resolution were young, highly educated Rabari who felt hindered in their progress due to their origins. They succeeded in arousing hope in the entire group for an immediate improvement in their situation if they would approve the constitution they had prepared. Meanwhile, this has been recognized as an illusion, and life largely continues according to the old traditions; nevertheless, they are proud of the constitution,³¹ which is currently in print, and insist on it with government representatives and foreigners. The hope that it will one day prove useful has not yet completely died out.

Sorathia Rabari in Gir Wald/Saurashtra

The Gir Forest was always considered an unfavorable area for cattle ranchers; the water was of poor quality, and diseases of all kinds endangered people and animals. Even more so than the Barda Hills, the forest was a refuge for those fleeing justice. Only during the great famine of 1899 did some of the Sorathia-Rabari migrate with their buffalo from the Barda Hills to the Gir Forest for the long term. There they encountered a group of Sorathia-Charan who had settled there before them. They themselves always maintained social and cultural ties with their original group, even though they multiplied to 1,000 families over the course of 70 years and could have established their own community in terms of numbers. However, in many respects, they became victims of their environment.

The Gir Forest belonged to the domain of the Babi Dynasty in Junagadh.³² It was formerly much more extensive and thus provided habitat for a greater number of wild and domestic animals. According to Talbot,³³ the forest area decreased from 1200 square miles to 480 between 1880 and

³¹ Saraswati. B., S. 195 - 204.

³² Vgl. Watson, 1884.

³³ Talbot, S. 78

1959. Wild clear-cutting and the expansion of cultivation under secure political conditions contributed to this, but even more devastating was the desertification of the landscape due to overgrazing.³⁴ The cattle herders crowded ever closer together in the developing forest area and felt the effects of overgrazing all the more acutely. In contrast to the Barda Hills, the influx and settlement of cattle herders in the forest were never regulated. Since intensive forestry practices began in recent years, the yei herders have also suffered from the 6-8 year closure of the areas, which are initially cleared and then immediately replanted. While a generation ago herds of 100 buffalo or more per family were the norm, today there are only 20-30 animals per herd. Due to the low quality of the feed, milk yield per animal has also decreased, so that people can only rarely live off the proceeds of their herds.

The Rabari find themselves in a situation they cannot resolve as livestock herders. Outside the forest, there is no space for their herds, as the land there is being used for agriculture. Within the forest, subsidies are only available for a few settlements of other caste members who have been cultivating the land for a long time due to sufficient water resources and are therefore recognized as villages. Many Rabari are willing to become farmers, but the existing village communities see them as unwanted competitors for the already scarce arable land. Now, the last lions of Asia live in the Gir Forest, and the forestry administration organizes lion shows as a lucrative tourist attraction. Since the wildlife population has been greatly reduced as a secondary consequence of overgrazing, the lions prey on domestic animals. For each animal killed, the Rabari receive compensation of approximately 40 cents. And at this price, they can also sell male cubs for the lion show, but this does not provide them with a livelihood.

The process of deteriorating living conditions outlined here has led to cultural impoverishment and a near-complete dissolution of the Rabari community. More and more, each individual tries to get by as best they can. It is assumed that some will be able to make a living as livestock farmers, while others will succeed in transitioning to agriculture, either within the forest or in its border areas. However, the majority of the Rabari are considering migrating to the cities, where they hope to find a livelihood as day laborers. The isolation of families has already progressed so far that communal activities are no longer even considered.

Chalakia-Rabari in southern Rajasthan

The settlement area of the Chalakia is the Godwad region, which stretches between Pali, Marwar Junction, Phola, and the Aravalli Mountains. They migrated in many small groups over centuries into their present territory as shepherds. The small migrating groups received permission to settle from the local landowners under various conditions. We visited the village of Purada, which had been gifted to a Raj Purohit family by the Maharaja. The village comprised 250 houses, 15 of which formed the Rabari residential quarter on the village's outskirts. Almost all villages in this area have

³⁴ Overgrazing means that grass-loving large animals, cows and buffaloes, are kept in too large numbers for the available food options. The grass is reduced in favor of herbs and bushes and finally destroyed. Sheep and goats take the place of large animals. If further grazing takes place, herbs and bushes of thorny desert vegetation finally give way.

such small groups of shepherds attached to them. For the right of residence, they must pay a nominal tax of 1 Rp per year per family, thereby acknowledging their subordination to the respective landowner. Traditionally, they earn money by selling young animals, ghi (clarified butter), and animal dung, in which the settled population is still so interested that they pay migrant groups 1 centime per night and 100 animals to drive them onto their harvested fields.

In response to the increasing population and the constant expansion of cultivation, which increasingly restricts grazing opportunities for all livestock farmers, the Chalakia have had to reduce the number of their sheep. Today, the resulting reduction in milk yield is no longer sufficient for ghi production, forcing them to sell unprocessed milk. The villagers have a need for this; however, since such a sale goes against the traditions of the livestock farmers, they have fallen far below the respect of their own and other castes. The formerly lucrative sale of male young animals for slaughter has become generally more difficult in the increasingly vegetarian Hindu society, and in their village-like environment, the Rabari find no market for them at all. As a replacement for this lost source of income, they have had to resign themselves to grazing the animals of the settled population as village herders, which offers them the sole advantage that their herd is also allowed to forage in the harvested fields.

Thus, this otherwise successful adaptation has put these Rabari on a path that will lead them further and further down the social ladder. They cannot increase their livestock numbers, and land ownership is not something they can expect. They also have no larger social organization, but only friendly relations with other neighboring Rabari groups, so that there are neither institutions nor individuals who could act in an authoritative official capacity for this community, which is fragmented into individual groups.

Rabari in North Gujrat

From Palanpur to Mehsana and around the capital Ahmedabad are the Rabari people who have been in transition to agriculture for about 100 years. There are no reliable figures on their numbers; they themselves estimate their population at 100,000, which simply means "very many". The problems of this group lie not so much in the process of conversion to agriculture, which is largely complete, but rather in the current situation of the farmers. We were unable to investigate this situation, as we were focused on the livestock herders.

Rabari In Ahmedabad

The only information available about the number of Rabari in Ahmedabad comes from their own sources; they are not listed separately in any official statistics. The lowest estimate was 10,000, the highest 25,000. The first influx occurred 80-100 years ago, when the Rabari mentioned in the previous section began farming. These immigrants settled on what was then the outskirts of the metropolis, as the animals found pasture there, and it was easier to drive them to the villages of the family members left behind by the migrants. Gradually, the rapidly expanding city, with its large textile factories, grew up around these settlements. The Rabari had to switch to stall feeding and,

over time, became content with easily selling unprocessed milk, for which there was an insatiable demand in the metropolis. Because the Rabari's neighbors felt disturbed by the animals being kept in such confined spaces, the Rabari were assigned so-called settlements on the outskirts of Ahmedabad 20 years ago. However, the city expanded faster than the administrators had anticipated, and the stables are now located in the middle of residential areas. The city has again offered the Rabari the opportunity to relocate the stables, which the Rabari themselves are interested in, but they are now making certain demands regarding the size of the area for the animals, housing for the people, access to water and electricity, and the construction of schools. To enforce these demands, they have formed a "union" represented by lawyers from their own caste.

This group of Rabari has taken advantage of the social advancement opportunities available to them since moving to the city. 70 to 80 percent of their boys and 20 percent of their girls are said to attend school today. Although 80 percent still primarily depend on milk sales for their livelihood, the percentage of men earning money, or supplementing their income, through unskilled or skilled labor is increasing. A small percentage already received higher education in the previous generation and are now pursuing university education for their offspring. The Rabari owe it to these educated members of the community that they receive expert assistance in their struggle for survival. The Rabari of Ahmedabad will be of great importance for the future of the entire caste and also see it as their duty to work towards improving their situation and raising their standing, since despite all official efforts, caste affiliation still influences a man's chances of advancement. To achieve these goals, they are collaborating with the great Vadvala Temple in Dudhrej/Surendranagar, North Saurashtra.

The Temple Vadvala

This temple is generally considered the sanctuary of the Rabari. It is a stopover for all Rabari traveling east from Kutch and vice versa. They are provided with free food and can sleep safely within the temple walls.

The temple's founding dates back to a Jhala-Rajput in 1612 AD; the further history of the sanctuary cannot be discussed here. From the beginning, celibate Rabari were the priests of the temple, where Vishnu is primarily worshipped today. Endowments have made the temple rich in money and land. For a long time, the temple has sent messengers throughout the land, inviting the Rabari to the temple festival in April. These messengers have fixed routes that take them as far as Kutch, Kaira, Baroda, Ahmedabad, Modasa, Idar, Dholka, Jodhpur, and Chela. They are often on the road for months. Previously, they only visited the nomadic groups, but now they also visit the settled communities. In many places, there are trusted people of the temple who, as local contacts, advise the messengers. All Rabari of renown and importance receive a personal invitation, on which the necessary information about the festival is printed and the individual's name is handwritten. These cards, decorated with colorful and gold lettering, are often brought out and passed around by the honored individuals, reminding all those present of the upcoming festival and recalling past festivals.

The increased activity of the messengers in recent years has had the desired success. More and more Rabari see the Vadvala Temple as their temple, even if they do not attend the festival and do not abandon their old local and family goddesses. The growing willingness to accept recognition is also fueled by the fact that the lower castes are increasingly concerned about their situation and future, and the messengers discuss such matters with them. The Rabari are also looking within their own ranks for representatives who can show them paths into the future and whom they can follow. The Rabari from Ahmedabad, in particular, expressed this sentiment. However, since they are a small and economically weak group in the metropolis, they have little prospect of making their interests heard and prevailing there. The large crowd of Rabari at the temple festival in Dudhrej seemed to be the right forum to discuss issues of general interest and to make decisions. For the 1969 festival, a large number of Rabari from Ahmedabad appeared, filled with the idea of benefiting themselves and the common cause.

Conclusion

The preceding overview shows that each group of the Rabari has historically grown into a situation that poses particular problems of adaptation. Nevertheless, the individual scenarios clearly show which possibilities for conversion - in addition to other situation-related special routes - basically exist for all cattle breeders. There are only two main directions of adaptation: either they give up their old way of life, or they try to assert themselves as cattle breeders. If the Rabari decide to give up their old way of life, it is closest to the majority to move on to the cultivation activity familiar to them through their own experience or contact. In addition, they can continue to carry out livestock farming under changed aspects. If they take this path, their main concern is to obtain land from the government, to lease it or to buy it. A break with all traditions, on the other hand, means emigrating to the city as a casual worker, as the example of many Sorathia-Rabari from the Gir forest showed. There are often wrong, i.e. too positive ideas about the earning potential in the city.

If the Rabari try to assert themselves as livestock farmers, they can rarely do so while maintaining their old habits. Only a few Kutchi will be able to keep themselves as pure camel breeders for some time and only a few Sorathia as pure buffalo breeders. A reduction of status and prosperity brings the path of the Chalakia, namely to reduce one's own livestock in such a way that they are sustainable for a village community and, moreover, to specialize as milk suppliers and village shepherds. The reorientation of the Dhebarya, on the other hand, to the animals and products desired by the market - meat and wool - has so far been successful and also opens a new path into the future, if they take the distribution of their goods into their own hands as a trader. The establishment of a cooperative of milk producers in Ahmedabad also seems to have a good outlook to secure the existence of this group. The suggestion for such ideas is undoubtedly due to the big city environment, which is more modern in every respect, which opens up ways of change for the individual members of this group and increasingly their descendants, which are still closed to provincial groups, but can have an example.

It is surprising that neither government representatives³⁵ nor development experts have provided for aid measures for livestock farmers as livestock farmers, at least none have been effective so far. There is an increasing demand for the products produced by the breeders: meat, wool, dung, especially Ghee and milk. Until now, there is a tendency to expect all these products from the farmer, who, however, is less and less up to the demands of the rapidly growing population with its small peasant farm and often outdated methods of land ordering. Especially areas that are not usable for farmers still offer many cattle breeders living opportunities, so that an official contribution to this little-noted group could help not only the cattle breeders but also the rest of the population.

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³⁵ With a few exceptions, such as Premjibhai Thakkar, who was Revenue Minister in Ahmedabad in 1968 and organized state-supported evasive migrations for the cattle ranchers suffering from this hunger for years.

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